with the onset of winter), satisfactory gains in the western sector, and the prospect of unwanted international involvement. But Beijing's political objectives had been met: it had established its dominance over New Delhi and sent a signal to Moscow. In other words, China felt India had been put in its place.

Several lessons can be drawn from India's failures in managing differences with China between 1950 and 1962. The underlying causes of the conflict— the ambiguities of the boundary and the question of Tibet— were realities that India inherited from the British. But one of India's fundamental errors was its misreading of China's domestic politics, its ideological imperatives, and the international environment. Mao's position after the failure of the Great Leap Forward and the developments at the crucial August 1962 leadership meeting were completely missed. Zhou's silence and the contents of the 1954 agreements were mistakenly interpreted in New Delhi as China's acquiescence of India's positions. On balance, therefore, India's understanding of Communist China proved poor. On the international front, Nehru clearly underestimated the reputational costs that China was willing to bear. The Soviet Union, which had until 1962 been tilting towards India, ultimately opted to side more with China, in part for its support during the ongoing Cuban Missile Crisis.

There was also a dire lack of Indian preparation for a major conflict, whether in terms of military plans and equipment, logistics, or intelligence. This was understood by some military and intelligence officials, and belatedly by political leaders as well. Indian forces were not deployed at strength, with the Chinese enjoying an almost 3:1 advantage in the western and eastern sectors. Moreover, the Indian Air Force was not seriously utilized, with no offensive air support. [111] Particularly after China's 1964 nuclear test, the yawning security discrepancy led to greater calls for an Indian nuclear deterrent. The 1962 outcome, along with the 1965 war with Pakistan, also exposed deficiencies in intelligence which were partly remedied by the creation of the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) in 1968 for intelligence on foreign targets. [112] Finally, a lack of clarity about